

DISCONTINUITY

When my niece, Emily, came to stay with me after her parents' accident, I did wonder about just not mentioning the catacombs. But you never know with teenage girls, do you? They have a way of tearing back the curtain on anything you try to hide from them. Besides, she was seventeen, old enough to understand why she shouldn't go exploring through uncharted underground passages alone.

That morning, as I looked into the basement and saw the door leading into the catacombs unlocked and ajar, I realised that I had made a very serious mistake.

Obviously, I still double checked inside the house. Sure enough, she wasn't in her room—and nor was her handbag, phone, or coat. I called her mobile while checking the rest of the rooms. No response, and no sign of her. It was 6:55 am, far too early for her to already be awake.

With a forceful sigh, I returned to the basement and pulled the door to the catacombs fully open.

"Emily?"

My voice came out quieter than I intended, as though I was afraid of bothering her. I tried again, louder and with more urgency, but the dark stone passage swallowed my voice without even an echo. It somehow felt even less responsive than talking to a wall.

I did another circuit of the house, calling out Emily's name, and phoned her mobile again. Still nothing.

I realise what I did next will seem crazy. You must understand, the gravity of the situation hadn't sunk in yet, and I was still in the stage of frustration at my morning schedule being disrupted. I hadn't even had my coffee yet. I just wanted to make the situation go away, I'm sure you can sympathise.

Quickly, sternly, I headed upstairs, put on my shoes and coat, and grabbed a ball of yarn from my knitting supplies in the front room. I tied the end to the wooden column at the bottom of the basement stairs and turned to face the passage. Was the door a little further open than I had left it? Surely not.

I felt the sensation one feels on a roller coaster as it crests the first hill. The cardboard boxes, broken chair, and boiler took on a vividly flat look in the light of the bare halogen bulb hanging from the ceiling.

It didn't matter. I was just going to go in and search around for a few minutes, or until I ran out of yarn, and then come back. Emily couldn't have gone far, and she'd surely hear me calling her name sooner or later. I took a deep breath and entered.

The passage continued straight on for around twenty metres, angling noticeably downwards after the first ten. The light on my phone didn't illuminate more than a few steps ahead. The space soon opened up into a crossroads.

"Emily?" I called out. Nothing.

Well, I thought to myself, if I were a teenager reckless enough to wander into a place like this, then I surely wouldn't be sensible enough to do the trick

of following the left or right hand wall. With a smirk, I headed forwards, yarn unravelling behind me.

The tunnel arced to the right a little, with another branch off to the left. I took a few turns without really paying too much attention, mostly just trying to cover some ground, and shouting at every intersection. I walked with a quiet sense of wonder, the low arched brick ceiling and narrow walls so refreshingly unfamiliar.

I was beginning to feel I could almost forgive Emily this indiscretion. If I were her age, I probably wouldn't have been able to resist something this fun either. However, the further I went, the more a sense of worry began to tickle at me from behind. I was relieved when I felt the yarn go taut, meaning I could follow it back home.

I turned, and the line went loose—probably just settling against the walls, I thought. Then, without me moving, it pulled even tighter than before. It felt like someone was on the other end trying to tug it out of my hand. I stood in place like a startled rabbit. Then, all at once, it fell to the ground.

“Emily?” I called out, voice cracking. “Emily, is that you?”

I held my breath, straining for any sound whatsoever. The silence was so complete it felt artificial, as though somebody had meticulously scooped out the natural background noise.

“Oh God,” I exhaled, the sound disappearing into the air like cigarette smoke.

This was too much. I retraced my steps stiffly, gathering up the yarn as I went, going as fast as I could without bumping my head against the low ceiling. In under a minute, I reached the end of the line. It dangled limply from my fingers, the end loose and frayed. There was no sign of the door back to my basement, nor of the rest of the yarn.

“Emily! Come out right now!”

I tried to speak with authority, but it came out sounding like pleading.

Obviously, there was no response. I circled the area back and forth looking for the rest of the yarn, agitation frothing up inside me. The tunnels sprawled out in branch after branch. None of them seemed like the crossroads I had first arrived at, but would I even recognise it if I saw it?

With an acrid burning sense of shame and helplessness, I admitted to myself that I was lost.

It was now 7:46 am, and my phone had 81 percent of its battery remaining. And—somehow—one bar of reception. I watched the symbol, expecting it to vanish like a field mouse under my gaze, but it stood firm. It felt distinctly wrong that I should have reception down here.

The significance was not lost on me, however. I dialled 999 and hit the call button. There were two slow rings, then a woman's curt voice in my ear.

“Emergency. Which service?”

Simultaneously, my phone extinguished its light, and I fell, stunned, into the darkness. The woman repeated herself, sharper this time.

“Emergency. Which service?”

“Yes, I'm, um, stuck in this labyrinth.”

"Which of your limbs is trapped?"

"No, I'm not stuck like that. I can walk fine."

"Okay ma'am, please exit the labyrinth."

"I can't," I begged, "I'm lost."

"Look over the walls of the labyrinth."

"There aren't any!"

Obviously, that wasn't what I meant to say.

"I mean—" I tried to correct myself, but she interrupted me.

"What exactly is your emergency?"

I swallowed.

"I went into the labyrinth in my basement, and I lost my way. I'm lost."

"Is anybody injured?"

"No."

"Is anything on fire? Is there any criminal activity?"

"Well, no."

There was a pause, the length of a single breath.

"Ma'am, which service do you require?"

"I don't know! Just please send someone to find me. And—" how could I have forgotten? "—my niece, I think she's down here somewhere too."

"All right. Can you give me details of the missing person?"

"Her name is Emily Lawson. She's five foot five, long brown hair, hazel eyes."

"Age?"

"Seventeen."

"Any identifying characteristics? Scars, tattoos, piercings?"

"No, no, nothing like that."

There was still no light. It felt like my eyes should have begun to adjust by now, but I was in the same uniform anchorless darkness.

"When and where did you last see her?"

"Last night, at home. The light was still on in her room at nine P.M."

"And 'home' is?"

"Twelve Castle Lane, Norwich."

"Thank you. I'll pass that information on for you. Two police officers will be by in around an hour to interview you about the missing person in more detail, please make sure you're there to let them in."

I sighed and hung up. My gaze bore down into the glowing rectangle in my hand, my fingers knotted around it like driftwood. Perhaps I should've been clearer about my situation. Perhaps I should call back, I thought. But what if I got a different operator, and had to explain everything again?

And should I stay where I was or keep moving? If I moved, I might lose the one bar of reception I already shouldn't have. But if I stayed, I might never get out. I wasn't even certain that anyone was looking for me. I stood, paralysed in indecision, feeling the pressure behind my eyes that might precede tears.

In the midst of this, I realised something. I was going to be late to work. A dry laugh burst out of my throat, but the echo reflected from the walls sounded

more like sobbing. I looked back at my phone—68 percent battery left—and dialled my boss's number.

"Hello?"

"Hey, it's Christina. I'm afraid I'm going to be late to work today. I'm—well, I'm stuck in a labyrinth."

There was a very long silence, long enough for me to wonder if the connection had cut out.

"You're stuck in... uh, traffic, did you say?"

"Yeah, traffic. Sorry."

"Can you hurry up? You're supposed to be leading the ten o'clock marketing meeting."

"Sorry. You might have to go ahead without me."

He sighed audibly.

"Have you at least got the quarterly report finished?"

"Yes! I just need to redo the last few graphs with the new data. Other than that it's done."

"Right. Is there anything else?"

"No sir."

Why did I call him sir? I never do that.

"All right. Let me know when you get into the the office. And, Christina?"

"Yeah?"

"Don't call me while you're driving. It's not safe."

Click.

This must be what being insane feels like, I thought to myself.

I slumped against the brick wall. The cold slowly seeped through my jacket into my spine. I thought about crying, but the tears weren't coming and I didn't feel like forcing it. I breathed out fully, dropped the phone into my lap, and held my hands out at ten and two. My focus settled in the middle distance, somewhere in the seam between two bricks. I went through the motions of checking my mirrors, turning the key, shifting into gear, and releasing the handbrake. This could be me right now.

I couldn't be that far underground, right? There was, at most, a few metres between me and the roiling mass of life I was momentarily separated from. I closed my eyes and focused, trying to listen for the rumble and honk of traffic. Nothing.

I heaved myself back to my feet and continued walking. The darkness ebbed away from my light like a silent viscous liquid. It retreated only reluctantly, clinging to the edges of the brickwork, and immediately flooding in behind my back. I had long since given up trying to recognise any of the identical corridors, forks, crossroads or dead ends, so my mind was untethered, free to float away.

This space was so absent of detail, so nothingful, it seemed hard to believe in it even as it clicked under my feet. Indeed, the more I thought, the less I believed. Why would there be a labyrinth like this under the city? Why would it connect onto my basement? Why would I even be here? And yet here I was,

with the broken yarn still coiled around my finger, and my phone battery still ticking downwards. 39 percent, 38 percent, 37 percent.

I noticed the noise before anything else. Long, low, rhythmic, like a washing machine spin cycle. Then I saw the small dim shapes on the ground in front of me—a single sewing needle, a green cardigan crumpled like a beached jellyfish, an enamel pin with a rose design, a primary school workbook with my name on the front. All former belongings that I'd thought lost. I took a few more faltering steps forwards, and more and more intimate objects emerged in front of me.

A nauseating mixture of sentimentality and terror began to crawl up my throat. Before it could get far, however, my phone jumped in my hands, blaring its ringtone. I shrieked, dropped it, and scrambled on the floor to pick it back up, my trembling hand brushing against an unreturned children's library book. I pressed the accept call button and held the phone against my ear.

"Hi, I'm calling back about the missing persons case."

"Yes?" I rasped. There was a slow shuddering, scraping sound somewhere ahead of me.

"We've located Emily, it seems she sneaked away to a house party last night and only got home around an hour ago. If you're out with a search party, you can return now."

"Ah, thank you." I could barely take in her words, as I was focusing on the approaching noise: a heavy tap, tap, tap of—were those high heels?

"If there's nothing else," she continued in a melodic, fawning voice, "would you mind answering a short survey about your experience of our service today? It would really help—"

"Sorry, I have to go," I breathed, running the sentence together into a single word.

I ran blindly, fumbling to end the call, turn my phone light back on, and avoid tripping over anything underfoot. The tapping approached behind me, slow and powerful. I slammed shoulder first into a brick wall. A dead end. Hadn't I come from this way?

I whimpered, waving the phone light around in desperation. The bricks stared back, unapologetic. The noise approached, faster now, and I could hear something deeper underneath, something like hoarse breathing, or growling. I dropped the phone, light pointing up, silhouetting me against the arched ceiling, and began to claw at the bricks above. My fingernails broke against the brickwork, but with sheer force, I managed to loosen and dislodge a single brick directly above.

Like a drowning person yearns for air, I yearned for the surface. If only I could have back my quarterly reports, and commutes, and ten o'clock meetings with marketing, I would never wish for anything again, I thought. But then I felt the hand grasp my shoulder, and that was the end.